

CHAPTER 6

The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation

NCERT Exercise Solutions

The Big Questions	3 Q
What Is a Civilisation? · Think about it	1 Q
What Is a Civilisation? · Let's explore	1 Q
From Village to City · Let's explore	1 Q
Town-Planning · Think about it	1 Q
Town-Planning · Let's explore	1 Q
Water Management · Let's explore	1 Q
Water Management · Think about it	1 Q
What Did the Harappans Eat? · Let us explore	1 Q
A Brisk Trade · Let's explore	1 Q
The Lives of the Ancients · Think about it	1 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡
answers are samples: write your own.

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? The Big Questions

1 What is a civilisation?

✔ ANSWER

A civilisation is an advanced stage of human society. It has:

- some form of government and administration
- urbanism (planned towns, water management, drainage)
- a variety of crafts
- internal and external trade
- some form of writing
- cultural ideas (art, architecture, customs)
- a productive agriculture that feeds villages and cities

2 What was the earliest civilisation of the Indian Subcontinent?

✔ ANSWER

The **Indus, Harappan or Indus-Sarasvatī (Sindhu-Sarasvatī) Civilisation**, in the northwest of the Subcontinent.

Its cities grew around 2600 BCE; it is one of the oldest civilisations in the world.

3 What were its major achievements?

✔ ANSWER

- Planned cities with wide streets, often facing the cardinal directions
- Excellent water management: drains, brick wells, large reservoirs (Dholavira)
- Productive farming: barley, wheat, millets, pulses; first in Eurasia to grow cotton
- Crafts: carnelian beads, shell bangles, bronze tools
- Brisk trade by land, river and sea (dockyard at Lothal)
- Seals with a writing system

🤔 What Is a Civilisation? · Think about it

? Which of the above characteristics do you think is the most fundamental — that is, a characteristic essential to the development of all others?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A productive agriculture is the most fundamental.

Only when farmers grow more food than they need can cities survive, and people become free to work as rulers, craftspeople, traders and scribes.

Without enough food, government, towns, crafts, trade and writing could not develop.

What Is a Civilisation? · Let's explore

? For each characteristic in the list above, can you make a list of professions or occupations that might exist in such a society?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Characteristic	Professions
Government and administration	ruler, officials, record-keepers, guards
Urbanism	town planners, brick-makers, masons, drain cleaners, well-diggers
Crafts	potters, bead-makers, metal workers, weavers, shell-bangle makers
Trade	traders, boat-makers, sailors, cart drivers, porters
Writing	scribes, seal-makers
Cultural ideas	artists, sculptors, priests, storytellers, dancers
Agriculture	farmers, herders, fishers, plough-makers

From Village to City · Let's explore

? Match these Harappan cities (see the map, Fig. 6.3) with the modern state / region:

Harappan city	Modern state / region
Dholavira	Punjab

Harappa	Gujarat
Kalibangan	Sindh
Mohenjo-daro	Haryana
Rakhigarhi	Rajasthan

✔ ANSWER

Harappan city	Modern state / region
Dholavira	**Gujarat**
Harappa	**Punjab** (Pakistan)
Kalibangan	**Rajasthan**
Mohenjo-daro	**Sindh** (Pakistan)
Rakhigarhi	**Haryana**

🤔 Town-Planning · Think about it

? You may have come across the term 'Indus Valley civilisation' and noticed that we have not used it. Look at the map (Fig. 6.3): why is the term 'valley' obsolete?

✔ ANSWER

The map shows many sites far away from the Indus — along the Sarasvatī (Ghaggar-Hakra) in Haryana and Rajasthan, and in Gujarat (Dholavira, Lothal).

So the civilisation spread much beyond the Indus valley, and 'valley' does not describe it correctly.

⭐ Town-Planning · Let's explore

? **Have a debate in class about the last two interpretations of the Great Bath (a bath for the royal family only, or a tank used for religious rituals). Can you think of any others?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Royal bath: it is a special, well-built tank with small rooms around it — fit for the rulers.

Religious rituals: it is elaborate, kept clean with fresh water, and bathing is still part of many rituals in India (e.g. temple tanks).

Other ideas: a place for special festivals or ceremonies; a bath for priests before a ceremony; a place for welcoming important visitors.

We cannot be sure, as there is no inscription, text or traveller's account.

⭐ Water Management · Let's explore

? **Measure the length of your classroom, a school corridor or a playground with a measuring tape. Compare these lengths with the length of the largest reservoir in Dholavira (73 metres).**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Example: a classroom 8 m long → 73 ÷ 8 ≈ 9, so the reservoir is about **9 classrooms** long.

A corridor 30 m long → 73 ÷ 30 ≈ 2½ corridors.

(Use your own measurements.)

🤔 Water Management · Think about it

? Imagine the large number of workers required to build such a network of reservoirs. Who organised their work and gave them precise instructions? How were they paid (there was no money as we have today)? Was there a local authority to manage the cleaning? What clues do we get about this city's ruler and municipal administration?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Engineers or planners working for the city's rulers probably organised the work.
- Workers were probably paid in goods such as grain, food or cloth (barter).
- Regular cleaning suggests a local authority, like a municipality.
- Clue: Dholavira had a strong, organised government that could plan big projects and keep them running for a long time.

What Did the Harappans Eat? · Let us explore

? **Imagine you cook a meal in a Harappan house. What dish or dishes would you prepare, based on the data given above?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Wheat or barley rotis
- Dal (pulses) flavoured with turmeric and ginger
- A vegetable dish, or fish / meat
- Curd or milk (dairy products)
- Bananas for dessert

A Brisk Trade · Let's explore

? **Looking at these three Harappan seals (unicorn, bull, horned tiger) with some writing signs, what goes through your mind? Would you like to suggest any interpretations?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Each animal may be the symbol of a trader, family or city — like a logo or brand today.
- The signs may be the owner's name or the goods being sent.
- Seals were probably pressed on clay to mark and protect bundles of goods.

- Some animals, like the tiger, may also have had a religious meaning.

🤔 The Lives of the Ancients · Think about it

? Looking at the objects on pages 100 and 101, or any other pictured in this chapter, can you make out what activities or aspects of life were important for the Harappans?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Trade: stone weights, seals
- Crafts and tools: bronze chisel, pots
- Looking good: bronze mirror, ivory comb, beads, bangles
- Games and fun: gamesboard, terracotta whistle
- Religion and culture: 'Priest King', Pashupati seal, swastika, namaste figurine
- Art, dance and stories: Dancing Girl, thirsty crow pot

⭐ The Lives of the Ancients · Let's explore

1 Complete the story found on the Lothal pot. How was such a story remembered for more than 4,000 years, in your opinion?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

A thirsty crow found a pot with a little water at the bottom. It dropped pebbles into the pot one by one. The water rose, and the crow drank it and flew away happy.

It was remembered because parents and grandparents told it to children again and again (oral tradition), and it teaches a useful lesson: think cleverly and do not give up.

2 **Consider the 'Dancing Girl' figurine. What do you make of the attitude it expresses? Observe her bangles covering an entire arm. Where else in this chapter can you spot bangles worn in this manner? What conclusion should we draw?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

She stands confidently, hand on hip, relaxed and proud.

Bangles covering the arm are also seen on the seated terracotta figurine in 'namaste' (check the picture in your book).

Conclusion: some Harappan customs and ornaments have continued for over 4,000 years — still seen in Gujarat and Rajasthan.

? Questions, activities and projects

1 **Why does the civilisation studied in this chapter have several names? Discuss their significance.**

✔ ANSWER

- **Harappan:** Harappa was the first city of this civilisation to be excavated (1921).
- **Indus (Indus Valley):** the first sites were found in the Indus plains. 'Valley' is now dropped, as the civilisation spread much further.
- **Indus-Sarasvatī / Sindhu-Sarasvatī:** many sites lie along the Sarasvatī (Ghaggar-Hakra) river, so this name shows its full area.

Each name tells us something about how and where it was discovered.

2 **Write a brief report (150–200 words) summing up some of the achievements of the Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Achievements of the Indus-Sarasvatī Civilisation

The Indus-Sarasvatī civilisation is one of the oldest in the world. Around 2600 BCE, its villages and towns grew into cities such as Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira and Rakhigarhi.

Its cities were carefully planned, with wide streets facing the cardinal directions, an upper town and a lower town, and houses of good-quality bricks. Mohenjo-daro had the Great Bath and hundreds of brick wells.

Water management was excellent. Houses had bathing areas connected to covered drains. Dholavira had at least six large reservoirs, one 73 metres long.

Farmers grew barley, wheat, millets, pulses and vegetables, and were the first in Eurasia to grow cotton.

Craftspeople made carnelian beads, shell bangles and bronze tools.

Trade went by land, river and sea; Lothal had a huge dockyard. Seals with writing signs were used in trade.

The Harappans seem to have been peaceful, and much of their culture passed on to later Indian civilisation.

3 **Imagine you have to travel from the city of Harappa to Kalibangan. What are your different options? Can you make a rough estimation of the amount of time each option might take?**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

The two cities are roughly 200 km apart (check the map scale, Fig. 6.3).

In Harappan times:

- On foot: about 25 km a day → about 8 days
- Bullock cart: about 20 km a day → about 10 days
- Partly by boat on the rivers, then on foot

Today: by car or bus about 4–5 hours (but an international border must now be crossed).

4 **Let us imagine a Harappan man or woman being transported to an average kitchen in today's India. What are the four or five biggest surprises awaiting them?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- A gas stove that lights with a flame at once, without wood
- Water from a tap instead of a well
- Electric lights, fan and refrigerator
- Steel and plastic utensils, pressure cooker, mixer
- Packed foods, and new foods like potatoes, tomatoes and chillies

5 **Looking at all the pictures in this chapter, make a list of the ornaments / gestures / objects that still feel familiar in our 21st century.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- Ornaments: bangles covering the arm, bead necklaces, shell bangles
- Gesture: 'namaste'

- Symbol: swastika
- Objects: comb, mirror, clay pots, plough, weights, chisel
- Games and toys: gamesboard, whistle
- Story: the thirsty crow

6 **What mindset does the system of reservoirs at Dholavira reflect?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

It shows careful planning and foresight: saving every drop of water in a dry region.

It also shows teamwork, good engineering skill and an organised administration that cared for the needs of the whole community.

7 **In Mohenjo-daro, about 700 wells built with bricks have been counted. They seem to have been regularly maintained and used for several centuries. Discuss the implications.**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

- People had easy access to clean water close to their homes.
- There was a strong local authority that maintained the wells for centuries.
- The city was stable and peaceful for a long time.
- Harappans valued water, cleanliness and public health.

8 **It is often said that the Harappans had a high civic sense. Discuss the significance of this statement. Do you agree with it? Compare with citizens in a large city of India today.**

💡 **SAMPLE ANSWER**

Civic sense means caring for public places and following common rules.

Yes, I agree: Harappans kept covered drains, clean streets, maintained wells and reservoirs, and built small and big houses of the same quality.

Today, many city citizens throw litter, waste water and block drains. Others keep their areas clean and follow rules (e.g. Swachh Bharat). We can learn from the Harappans.

🎉 **Chapter 6 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**